

warming and viral infections that they contracted through their surroundings," says Shubha Raul, mayor of Mumbai. The dire state of the zoo isn't because the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), which runs the zoo, is cash-strapped. Far from it, the corporation is sitting on a Rs 480-crore corpus earmarked for revamping the zoo.

Free-ranging animals and large carnivores should not be confined," says Bittu Sahgal, wildlife expert and member of the Zoo Improvement Committee set up by the BMC in 2006.

The question, as Sahgal says, isn't about finance. The administrative body simply does not have the wherewithal to handle the zoo animals. "The superintendent of the zoo is a

and the forest secretary to provide clean food and water to the animals, and maintain hygienic conditions in enclosures. The orders fell on deaf ears. Non-governmental organisations like People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals (PETA) and PAWS have locked horns with the BMC and are urging them to close down the zoo and shift the animals to Sanjay



**A SOLITARY HYENA (LEFT);
THE CAGE OF THE LION WHO
DIED TWO YEARS AGO**



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CORPORATION'S BUREAUCRATS, WHICH SOMETIMES DELAYS DIAGNOSIS AND TIMELY TREATMENT.

The funds will not go into improving the living conditions of the zoo but giving it an 'international makeover'. The ambitious master plan will cover 53 acres and will introduce exotic foreign species like the African elephant and the polar bear, "to bring out the difference between Indian and foreign species", as a zoo official explains. It is not clear whether this involves reforming the existing bureaucracy which runs the zoo but clearly, the existing menagerie is off the radar. "The biggest problem the zoo faces is that there is no proper supervision and care for the animals. Rules are being flouted, cages are left open and animals are eating in the same place where they defecate.

horticulture expert who has no experience in handling wild or rare species of animals," says B.R. Sharma, member secretary of the Central Zoo Authority, Delhi. Veterinary doctors double up as administrative staff, dealing with paperwork instead of tending to sick animals. Zoo officials cannot even treat animals without the approval of BMC bureaucrats. "At times, this delays the diagnosis and timely treatment of animals," says a senior doctor from the Bombay Veterinary College. In 2007, for instance, it took zoo authorities six months to treat a sick panther by which time it had died.

Three years ago, the Bombay High Court directed the civic body

Gandhi National Park, Borivali. "Rani Bagh was never meant to be a zoo. It should be preserved as a botanical garden, but the animals must be moved to better facilities where their natural habitat is simulated," says Anuradha Sawhney, Chief functionary of PETA, India. In fact, Raul suggests the makeover must add naturalists, veterinary doctors as well as horticulture experts.

The only revamp needed, say environmentalists, is for the BMC to shed its apathy. Setting up open-plan enclosures for animals, providing them with good quality food, clean water and giving them timely medical help are just some of the urgent steps needed to save the zoo. ■